

Q.7a (20 marks): The technological system is both primary and deterministic in human life - Leslie White theory ...

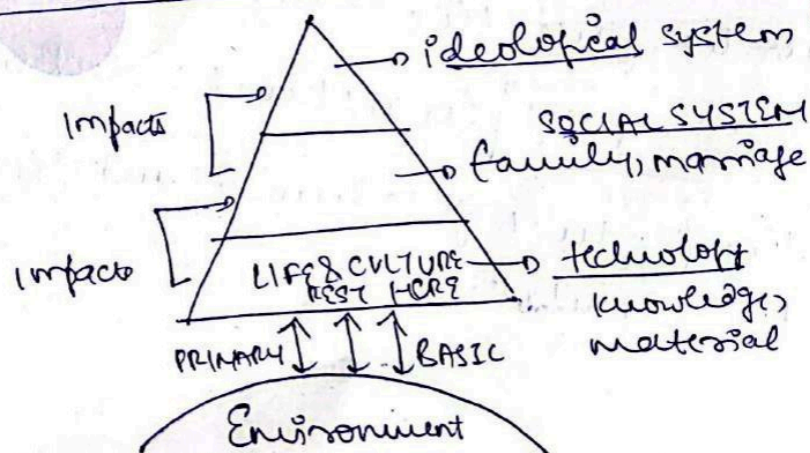
- Q7. (a) The technological system is both primary and basic in importance as all human life and culture rest and depend upon it. Elaborate the statement in keeping in mind Leslie White's theory of cultural evolution. (15 marks)

Leslie White's Theory of Cultural Evolution is called "technological determinism". He believed that technology was the basic system over which - social system and ideology depended on.

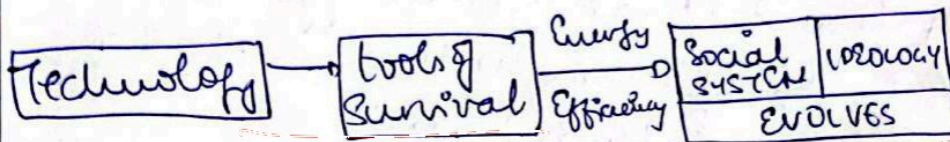
Cardinal Points of Theory of Cultural Evolution (Technology as primary and basic):

- ① Believed in "Culturlogy": one general law can explain all cultures. Thus he was a NEO-EVOLUTIONIST.
- ② Believed in Unilinear UNIVERSAL cultural evolution.
- ③ Stated that "Cultural Materialism" with energy per capita should be the theory of culture.

THE THREE SYSTEMS OF CULTURE :-



Technology: - He said helps us raise energy used per capita per year. This leads to efficiency in culture.



Thus technology is base and primary in life.

TYPOLOGY OF CULTURE AS PER TECHNOLOGY AND SYSTEM:

Paleolithic	use of <u>muscle</u> as technology (Hunting/gathering)
Neolithic	use of <u>plants and animals</u> as technology
Iron Age	use of <u>oil, fuel</u> etc
Energy Revolution	use of <u>nuclear</u> energy

Thus he gave the formula:-

$$C = T \times E \quad \text{is cultural evolution (C)}$$

is the product of technology and efficiency and accumulates.

Achievements and Tenets of Theory :-

- ① Gave an empirical and cross cultural reasoning to evolutionists (arm chair and ethnocentric).
- ② Inspired Marshall Sahlins and Elman Service to formulate general theories of parallelism and Convergence of culture based on technological system as a base.

Criticism :-

- ① Julian Steward said that general laws of culture are not sound. Each geography and region needs to be studied as MULTILINEAR evolution.
- ② He gave concept of culture ecology to counter the Julian White theory.
- ③ Moreover, it failed to explain why some cultures advance in technology and some degenerate.
- ④ Noy Nappaport said other facets of culture - religion etc ignored.

But, theory gave ETIC, OBJECTIVE and EMPIRICAL perspective to evolution.